

“ I GREET YOU
IN THE NAME
OF **PEACE,**
DEMOCRACY,
AND **FREEDOM.** ”

Nelson Mandela, ANC leader



Nelson Mandela and his wife Winnie punch the air in a victory salute after his release from Victor Verster prison. He was held in captivity for 27 years.

THE 30-YEAR BAN ON THE AFRICAN NATIONAL CONGRESS (ANC)

in South Africa was lifted by President De Klerk on February 2. This started the long process of **dismantling the apartheid system**. In sweeping reforms, De Klerk also announced that the outlawed South African Communist Party and the Pan-Africanist Congress would be allowed to resume legal political activities.

Nine days later, **Nelson Mandela** (b. 1918), the leader of the ANC, **walked free** after spending **27 years in jail**.

Neighboring **Namibia** became the 47th African country to **gain independence** after 25 years of struggle against South African rule. Sam Nujoma was elected as the first president in March.

In Central America, **free elections** were held in **Nicaragua** on February 25. National Opposition Union, a coalition of political parties backed by US funding, defeated the left-wing Sandinistas. Violeta Chamorro

(b. 1929) became the first female president of Nicaragua.

In the Persian Gulf, **Iraq invaded Kuwait** on August 2. The invasion was preceded by border disputes between the two countries, and Iraq's inability to repay money borrowed from Kuwait during the Iraq-Iran War (1980-88). On August 8, Iraqi leader **Saddam Hussein** (1937-2006) announced that **Kuwait had become a part of Iraq**. World leaders condemned the invasion. Soon after, allied forces led by the US were sent to the Gulf (see 1991).

On August 23, Saddam Hussein appeared on television with **Western hostages**, mostly of British origin, captured in Iraq. He denied accusations that he was using these hostages as "human shields" against a potential US-led coalition attack.

Farther north, Soviet troops were ordered into Baku, Azerbaijan, on the evening of January 19 to put down a separatist movement by **Azerbaijani nationalists**. The



LECH WALEŚA (1943-)

One of the founding members of Poland's Solidarity trade union movement, Lech Waleśa was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1983. In 1990, he became Poland's first post-communist president. He failed to gain a second term in office, as he had alienated voters with his erratic leadership style.

next day, thousands of Azerbaijanis set fire to their Communist Party membership cards.

Germany was reunited on October 3, nearly a year after the fall of the Berlin Wall (see 1989). Helmut Kohl (b. 1930) was elected as the first chancellor of the reunified nation.

On December 1, the **Channel Tunnel**, the world's longest undersea railroad tunnel linking Britain with France, came a step closer to completion. The construction workers drilled through the final section of rock to join the two halves of the tunnel.

War zone

Kuwait, a small oil-rich Arab nation, was annexed by neighboring Iraq. The seven-month-long occupation ended after military intervention by US-led forces in Operation Desert Storm, a largely air offensive.



A man tries to put out a fire at an oil well in Burhan, Kuwait. Iraqi troops had set alight more than 600 oil fields during their occupation of the country.

ON JANUARY 13, SOVIET TROOPS STORMED INTO LITHUANIA to suppress dissident nationalists. In the crackdown, 14 people were killed and more than 500 injured. Protestors had gathered to protect a TV station after a broadcast called for people to defend government buildings from the Soviet troops.

On June 13, **Boris Yeltsin** (1931-2007) became the first popularly elected president of Russia, inflicting a heavy defeat on the Communist Party. The win gave him a power base to challenge the incumbent leader of the Soviet Union, Mikhail Gorbachev (b. 1931).

A **military coup** attempted to remove Gorbachev from power when he was on holiday in August. Yeltsin organized a resistance and the coup collapsed on August 21. Subsequently, Yeltsin ordered the

Communist Party of the Soviet Union to end its rule in Russia.

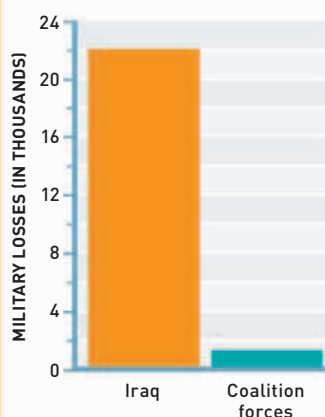
The **USSR disintegrated** into **15 separate countries** as the world looked on in amazement. On December 8, heads of three of the Soviet Union's 15 republics, Russia, Ukraine, and Belarus, met to disband the Soviet Union and form a new union, the **Commonwealth of Independent States**. On December 21, eight others joined it. After four days, Mikhail Gorbachev announced he was resigning as Soviet president; **the USSR was no more**.

Yugoslavia was also breaking up—**Slovenia and Croatia declared independence** in June. Serban president Slobodan Milosevic sent troops to both regions to stop them from seceding. The city of Vukovar in eastern Croatia was devastated after a three-month siege by Serbs, which ended in November.

In **Northern Ireland**, the main political parties held an **historic meeting** on June 18 to discuss the future of the province. Northern Ireland had suffered years of sectarian violence and there was an overwhelming public desire to end bloodshed.

Peace talks were also held on the **Middle East** between Arabs and Israelis in Spain, on October 30. It was the first time in over 40 years that Israel had sat down with all its Arab neighbours to discuss peace.

Elsewhere, the **United Nations (UN) issued an ultimatum** to Saddam Hussein to withdraw Iraqi troops from Kuwait by January 15



Iraq-Kuwait war casualties

The superiority of coalition forces is starkly illustrated by the disproportionately heavy losses inflicted on the Iraqi military.

